

China: Trade growth moderated in July

Bottom line:

China's trade growth moderated in July, with exports slightly above consensus expectations and imports moderately below (exports: +23.9% yoy, imports: +27.5% yoy). The slowdown in headline trade growth partly reflected unfavorable base effects and adverse weather conditions. By region, China's nominal exports to most economies fell sequentially in July, while exports to ASEAN, Japan and the EU rose. Chinese imports from major trading partners fell sequentially, except for Japan. By product, export values of AI-related goods continued to rise, while automobile exports fell. The moderation in import growth in year-over-year terms was broad-based across products, except for AI-related goods and coal, though price effects remained dominant. Overall, the trade surplus narrowed to US\$112.5bn, down from US\$125.6bn in June.

Asia-MAP Scores:

Exports: 0 (3, 0)

Imports: 0 (3, 0)

Key numbers:

USD-denominated:

Exports: 23.9% yoy in July (GS: 23.9%, Bloomberg consensus: 23.0%). June: 27.0% yoy. Sequential growth (seasonally adjusted by GS): 0.0% non-annualized in July vs. +5.5% in June.

Imports: 27.5% yoy in July (GS: 30.7%, Bloomberg consensus: 29.7%). June: 36.0% yoy. Sequential growth (seasonally adjusted by GS): -2.4% non-annualized in July vs. +6.9% in June.

Trade balance: US\$112.5bn NSA in July (GS: US\$105.4bn, Bloomberg consensus: US\$107.1bn). June: US\$125.6bn.

RMB-denominated:

Exports: +20.8% yoy in July vs. +13.7% yoy in June.

Imports: +29.4% yoy in July vs. +21.5% yoy in June.

Main points:

1. In year-over-year terms, China's trade growth moderated in July, partly due to the unfavorable base effects and adverse weather conditions. Exports increased by

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23.9% yoy (vs. 27.0% yoy in June), and imports increased by 27.5% yoy (vs. +36.0% yoy in June; [Exhibit 1](#)). In sequential terms, exports remained roughly flat in July (vs. +5.5% sa non-annualized in June), while imports decreased by 2.4% sa non-annualized in July (vs. +6.9% in June). China's trade surplus decreased to US\$112.5bn in July (not seasonally adjusted), vs. US\$125.6bn in June ([Exhibit 2](#)). Today's release of trade data only covers major trading partners and products.¹ The detailed breakdown of trade by country and by product will be released on August 20.

2. By major destination, Chinese nominal exports to most regions fell sequentially in July, while exports to ASEAN, Japan and the EU rose ([Exhibit 3](#)). Imports from major trading partners also fell sequentially in July, except for Japan ([Exhibit 4](#)). Among major DM countries, China's exports to the US rose 17% yoy in July (vs. +13.9% yoy in June), with a sequential decrease of 0.7% (mom sa non-annualized). China's imports from the US increased by 15.3% yoy in July (vs. +25.9% yoy in June). Exports to the EU increased by 16.0% yoy in July (vs. +18.5% yoy in June), with a sequential gain of 0.3% (mom sa non-annualized). Imports from the EU fell by 1.4% yoy in July (vs. +9.2% yoy in June). Among major EM countries, exports to ASEAN and South Korea remained strong, rising 38.4% yoy and 46.6%, respectively (vs. +34.5% yoy and +42.6% yoy in June). Exports to Africa rose by 18.2% yoy in July (vs. +28.0% yoy in June), with a sequential decline of 2.5% (mom sa non-annualized). Imports from most EM economies moderated sequentially from June to July, while imports from regions producing AI-related products still posted positive sequential growth, including South Korea (+7.4% mom sa annualized), Taiwan (+0.2%), and Vietnam (+16.0%).

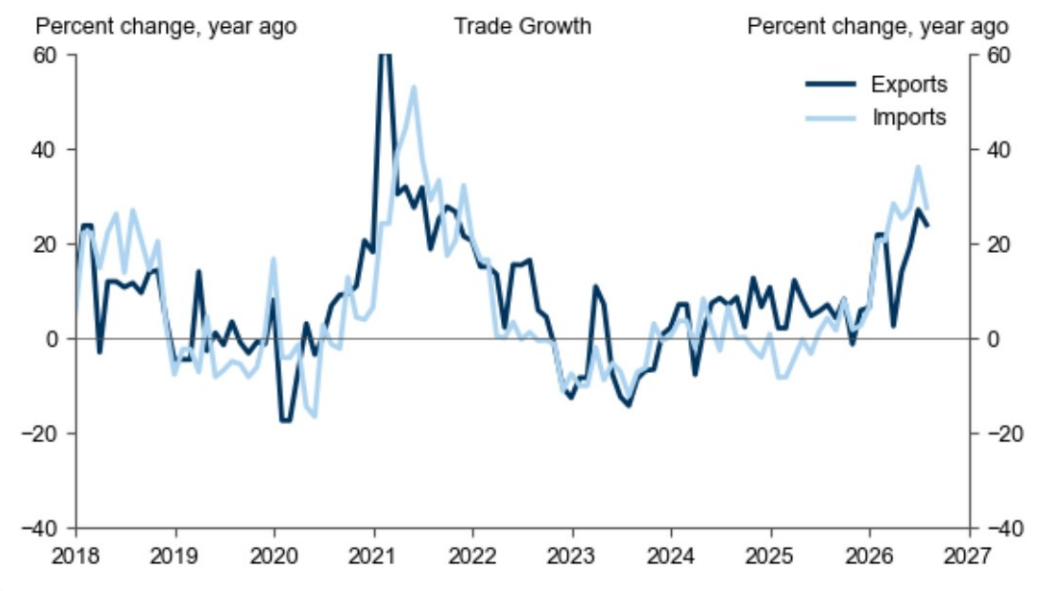
3. By major category and in sequential terms, export value of tech-related products (mainly semiconductors and automatic data processing machines), metals, and textile/apparel rose in July, while exports of automobiles and housing-related products fell ([Exhibit 5](#)). In year-over-year terms, among tech-related products, exports value of semiconductors moderated to 116.6% yoy in July (vs. 121.9% yoy in June), and export volume of semiconductors rose by 1.7% yoy in July (vs. -0.5% yoy in June). Among metal products, exports of aluminium increased by 44.8% yoy in July (vs. +77.0% yoy in June). Exports of rare-earth ores and minerals rose by 43.0% yoy in July (vs. +178.8% yoy in June), with volume falling by 29.5% yoy (vs. -34.0% yoy in June). Exports of automobiles rose by 60.4% yoy in July (vs. +70.0% yoy in June), with a sequential decline of 6.3% (mom sa non-annualized).

4. Among major categories and in sequential terms, import value fell broadly, except for semiconductors and energy products ([Exhibit 6](#)). Higher prices contributed to the increase in year-over-year import growth of semiconductors and energy products. Semiconductors import value increased by 71.1% yoy in July (vs. 72.3% yoy in June), while its import volume only increased by 8.5% yoy (vs. +6.6% in June). Among major energy products, import value of coal accelerated to 83.8% yoy in July (vs. +60.7% in June), while its import volume growth moderated to 20.0% yoy in July (vs. +29.5% yoy in June). Import volumes of crude oil and refined petroleum continued to decline, albeit at a slower pace, falling 24.3% yoy and 39.6% yoy (vs. -41.3% yoy and -48.6% yoy in June), respectively.

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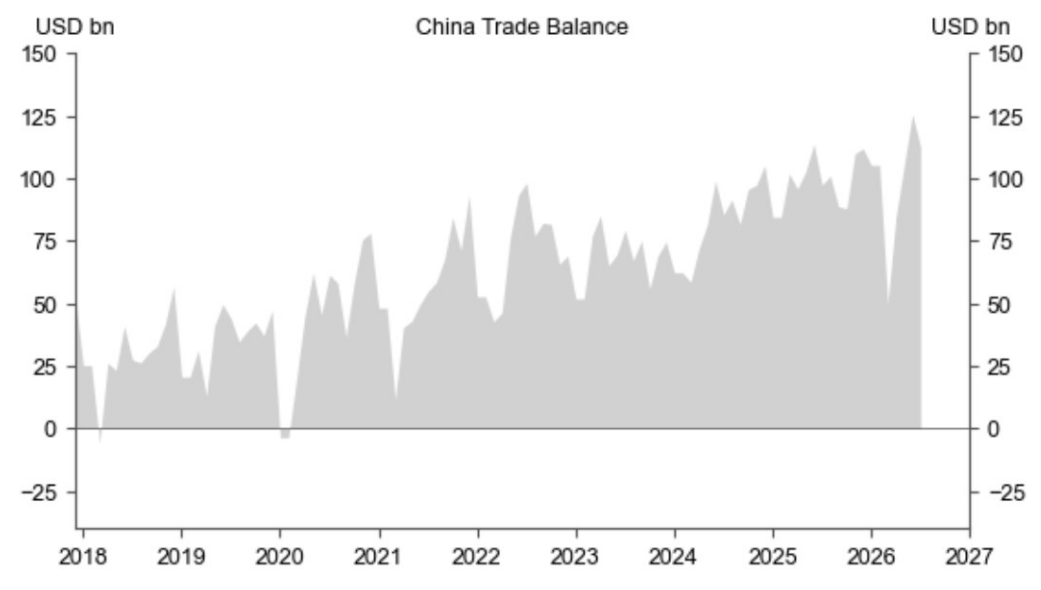
¹ Exports/imports by product cover around 40% of total exports/imports.

Exhibit 1: Year-over-year nominal trade growth moderated in July



Source: China Customs

Exhibit 2: China's trade surplus narrowed to US\$112.5bn in July



Source: China Customs

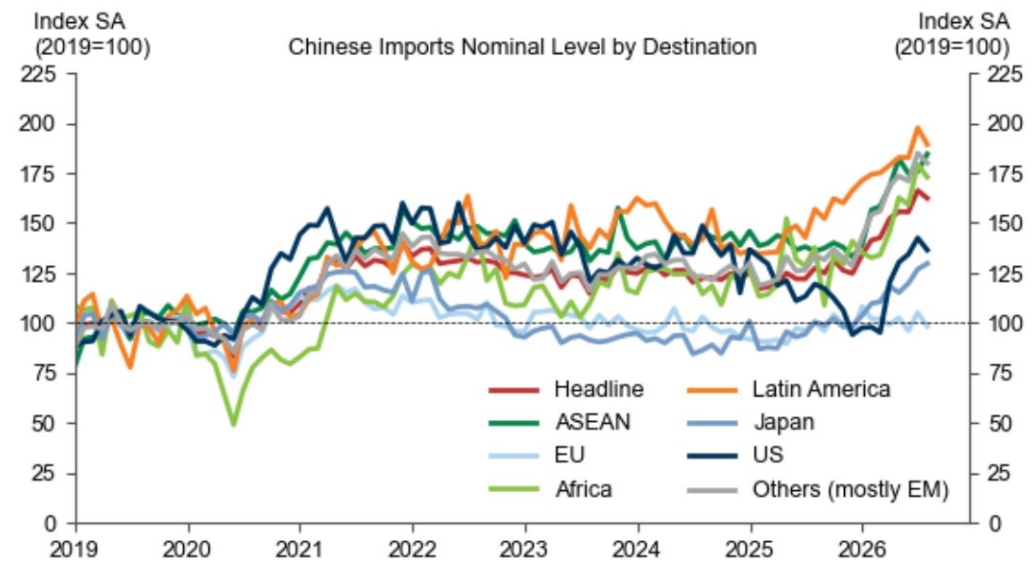
Exhibit 3: Chinese nominal exports to major economies fell sequentially in July, while exports to ASEAN, Japan and the EU rose



Chinese exports to the US/EU/Japan/ASEAN/LatAm/Africa were around 13.2%/14.6%/4.2%/17.1%/7.8%/5.4% of total exports in 2025. Overall they accounted for 62% of Chinese exports.

Source: China Customs, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

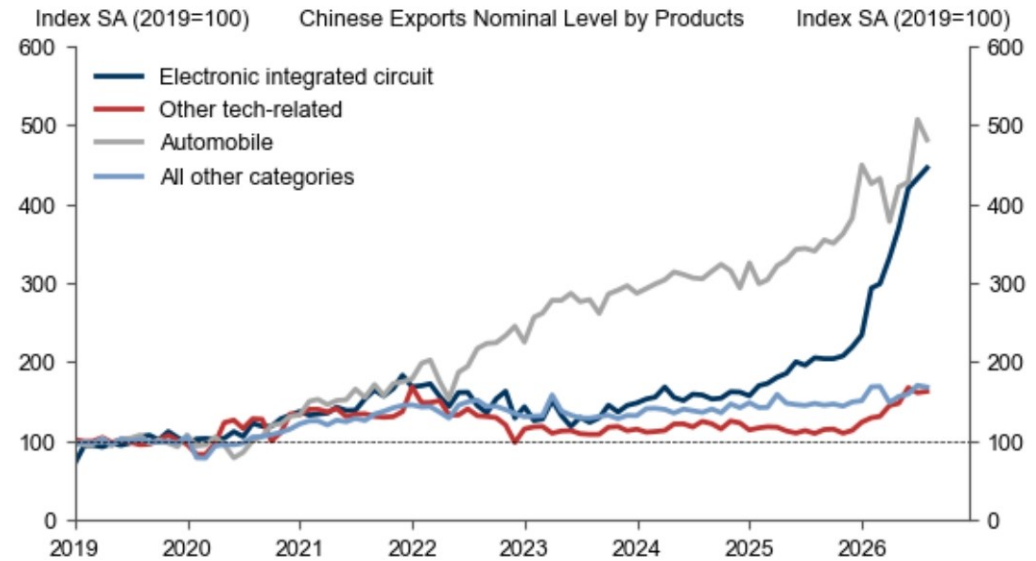
Exhibit 4: Chinese imports from major trading partners fell sequentially in July, except for ASEAN and Japan



Chinese imports from the US/EU/Japan/ASEAN/LatAm/Africa were around 6.1%/10.3%/6.2%/15.5%/9.3%/4.6% of total imports in 2025. Overall they accounted for 52% of Chinese imports.

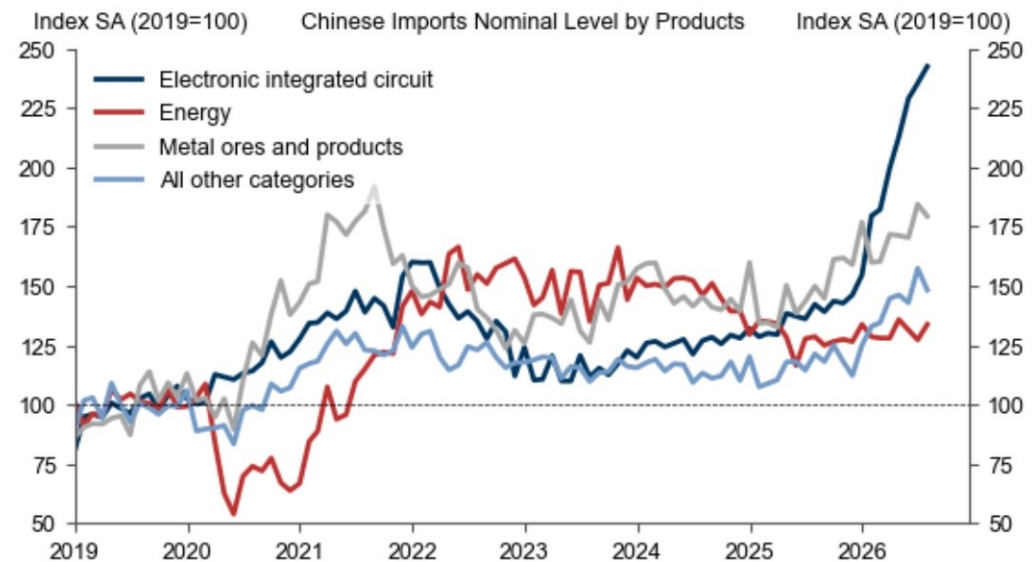
Source: China Customs, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 5: In sequential terms, exports value of semiconductors rose while automobiles exports fell



Source: China Customs, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 6: Imports fell broadly in sequential terms, except for semiconductors and energy products



Source: China Customs, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

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